TAKE-HOME EXERCISE 1

Async technical leadership

A dictation exercise: we want a window into how you think and communicate as a technical leader. This document contains everything you need — the pre-read, the exercise brief, and the submission criteria.

PART ONE	PART TWO	PART THREE
Pre-read	Exercise brief	Final output

PART ONE

Pre-read

What you will want to know before running through the Async Technical Leadership dictation exercise.

Before you start

1. You should have received a separate **candidate packet** covering Loom setup. Go through that packet first so you can create Loom videos for this exercise.
2. Read the **Final Output Document** next, so you know exactly what a complete submission looks like.
3. Then read the **Exercise Brief** and begin.

WORTH KNOWING

This is a dictation exercise. You will talk through your thinking on a recording rather than write an essay — a few minutes of bullet-point prep per module is all the preparation you need.

PART TWO

Exercise brief

This is an async interview artifact. We are evaluating how you think and operate in modern engineering work — especially judgment, scope, verification, and technical communication.

We are not scoring accent, grammar, charisma, or polish. We *are* scoring whether you can communicate technical work coherently, stay logically consistent over time, and ground your claims in specifics.

Submission format

Please submit a single Loom screen recording that includes:

- Audio and video — at least audio; camera optional
- Your screen where appropriate
- Loom's auto-transcript, or any transcript you can export

If your Loom gets cut off for any reason, multiple Looms are fine — but one is preferred.

PREP RULES — TO KEEP THIS FAIR

- Before each module, take 3–5 minutes to jot bullets and recall an example.
- Please do not read a fully scripted response.
- Using AI tools to help you outline is okay, but the recording should reflect your own understanding — you should be able to explain any claim you make.

Recommended timing

Modules 0–2 are the standard track. Modules 3–4 are optional.

Module 0	8–12 min	Module 1	12–18 min
Module 2	12–18 min	Module 3	8–12 min (optional)
Module 4	8–12 min (optional)	Typical total	35–50 min for 0–2 · 50–70 min for 0–4

How to structure your response

For each module that asks for a story, we recommend:

1. Start with a **30-second summary** — the headline.
2. Then answer in STAR-like structure: **context → constraints → actions → resistance and tradeoffs → result**.
3. As a bonus, add **durability** — what stuck, and what you would do differently.

Where possible we love to hear real metrics you moved: cycle time, defect rate, adoption, latency and cost, delivery date, staffing speed, revenue impact.

STORY CHECKPOINT · 1–2 MINUTES, SHORT BUT IMPORTANT

At the end of each story-based module, answer: "If someone were skeptical of my story, what's the weakest link or biggest uncertainty?"

Modules

MODULE 0

8–12 min · all candidates

Technical excellence

- What technical skills and tools are non-negotiable for someone in this role?
- What separates someone who is good at this job from someone who is great at it?
- What traits or working styles tend to fail in this role?
- What skills and attributes make you excellent at your job? Brag a little.

MODULE 1

12–18 min

Ownership under ambiguity

- **End-to-end ownership story:** a project where requirements were ambiguous and outcomes mattered. How did you frame the problem? What did you ship first, and why? How did you validate correctness and de-risk delivery?
- **Debugging and verification story:** a hard bug or failure mode you owned. What hypotheses did you form? What was your feedback loop? What prevented regression?

MODULE 2

12–18 min

Leverage and influence

- **Durable leverage artifact:** something you built or introduced that outlived you and changed how others shipped. What was it exactly? How did adoption happen? What evidence shows it stuck?
- **Direction without authority:** a time you set direction across stakeholders or teams you did not manage. What resistance existed? How did you win alignment? What was the outcome?

MODULE 3

8–12 min · optional, recommended

Delivery leadership

- **At-risk delivery, first 48 hours:** a project at risk on timeline, quality, or stakeholders. What did you do in the first 48 hours? Who did you loop in — and who did you not? What changed because of your actions?

MODULE 4

8–12 min · optional, high signal

Staff+ operating system

- **How you keep teams fast and safe:** the mechanisms you use to maintain quality at speed — eval gates, release discipline, observability, incident loops, testing strategy, standards. Give one concrete example and how you measured impact.

SUBMISSION CHECKLIST

- One or more Looms with accompanying transcript
- Clear module boundaries — say “Module 0…”, “Module 1…” as you go
- No confidential client code or sensitive details; generalize as needed

PART THREE

Final output

The submission criteria for the Async Technical Leadership dictation exercise.

Desired submission format

Please submit a single Loom screen recording that includes:

- Audio and video — at least audio; camera optional
- Your screen where appropriate

If your Loom gets cut off for any reason, multiple Looms are fine — but one is preferred.

BEFORE YOU SUBMIT

You should have received a separate packet detailing how to submit Loom videos. Follow those instructions so each recording is uploaded and shared to the right location in your private interview submission space.